Bhargav Gopal

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Work Experience

2023 -	Assistant Professor	Smith School of Business at Queen's University

Education:

2023	Ph.D. Economics	Columbia University
2015	B.A. Economics	University of California, Berkeley

Dissertation Committee: Sandra Black (Chair), Bernard Salanie, Suresh Naidu, Michael Best, Justin McCrary

Fields of Specialization: Labor Economics, Finance, Law and Economics

Publications

Non-Compete Agreements and Bargaining Power. *AEA Papers and Proceedings.* Volume 116, May 2026. (Joint with Xiangru Li and Luke Rawling)

Working Papers/Works in Progress

Do Non-Compete Agreements Help or Hurt Workers? Evidence from the NLSY97. CLEF Working Paper 89, February 2026 (Joint with Xiangru Li and Luke Rawling)

Abstract: While non-compete agreements (NCs) are common, the incentives driving their use across various segments of the labor market and effects on workers remain poorly understood. We show theoretically that for non-liquidity constrained workers, NCs compress the external wage profile and encourage firm-provided industry-specific human capital investments, which raises within-job wage growth. This model predicts NCs are used among workers with highly transferable skills. We also present a liquidity constraints model to understand NC usage among lower-wage workers. This model shows that NCs reduce costly turnover, but do not incentivize human capital investments. Lower-wage workers who sign NCs receive a compensating wage differential, but contracted wages will fall below marginal product, lowering the labor share of income. Using novel data on NC usage from the NLSY97, we find NCs are more commonly used among higher skilled workers who perform more sophisticated tasks and have higher returns on experience,

consistent with NCs being used to resolve hold-up problems. Using a stacked difference-in-differences research design, we find that NCs raise job tenures by 6% and immediately increase wages by 10%. Six years after signing, the wage premium falls to 5%. NCs increase wage growth for higher-wage workers but reduce wage growth for lower-wage workers. We find no evidence of increased investment in formal training or upgrading of skills, suggesting investments prompted by NCs are likely informal. Our findings caution against blanket bans on NC usage.

Human Capital, Search Frictions, and All-Male Corporate Boardrooms

Abstract: Why do firms maintain all-male boards: a shortage of qualified women or frictions in candidate search? To answer this question, I use California's 2018 board diversity mandate (SB826) and a difference-in-differences design comparing listed firms with all-male boards pre-reform in California to listed firms with all-male boards pre-reform headquartered elsewhere. I find the quota increased the female share of boards by 11 percentage points while increasing the share of out-of-network and first-time directors by 3 percentage points within three years. Besides top-level experience, other recorded measures of human capital and board quality remained stable. These results suggest that search frictions, rather than talent shortages, contribute to the frequency of all-male boards. I introduce a model of statistical discrimination where signal precision rises with a group's board representation. This dynamic, reflecting gender-segregated professional networks, rationalizes all-male boards as an equilibrium even when men and women draw talent from identical distributions. Finally, I show that the traditional shift-share instrumental variables approach substantially overstates first-stage and reduced-form point estimates due to mean reversion in board gender diversity and measures of firm profitability.

Mandatory Disclosure and Female Representation in Corporate Leadership: Evidence from NASDAQ (Joint with Dhruv Baswal, Tanvir Ahmed Khan, and Bailey Kraus)

Abstract: We study how firms and financial markets respond to mandates requiring disclosure of information. The context is NASDAQ's 2021 board diversity rule, a comply-or-explain regulation requiring listed firms to disclose board gender composition and either appoint at least one female director or explain non-compliance. Unlike gender quotas, this disclosure-based mandate operates through market pressures rather than financial penalties, allowing reputational concerns to shape firm behavior. Using NYSE-listed firms as a control group, we find that mandatory disclosure increases female board representation by 4%, with effects concentrated among larger firms and those with higher pre-regulation Environmental, Social, and Governance ratings. Event-study evidence shows abnormal returns of approximately 0.7% for NASDAQ firms around regulatory approval and -1.3% around judicial repeal, with larger effects for firms with all-male boards. We provide suggestive evidence the positive valuation effects arise due to the regulation reducing information asymmetries. Firms that choose to explain most often cite supply-side constraints such as an inability to find qualified candidates. Our findings indicate that mandatory disclosure generates positive valuation effects but only modestly increases gender diversity in corporate leadership.

Non-Compete Agreements as Barriers to Entry (Joint with Xiangru Li)

Abstract: Non-compete (NC) agreements became easier to enforce across U.S. states from the early 1990s to 2014, the same period in which firm entry declined and the economy shifted toward older, larger firms. We study how changes in NC enforceability affect establishment entry and exit. We combine Business Dynamics Statistics data with state-level enforceability scores from Johnson, Lavetti, and Lipsitz (2025) and estimate a stacked difference-in-differences design. A 0.1 increase in enforceability, close to the average change per event, lowers the entry rate by 0.45 percentage points and raises the exit rate by 0.68 percentage points. Younger and smaller firms drive the rise in exit, and the share of startups falls. Using NLSY97 data to classify industries, we find larger entry declines in knowledge-intensive industries and those that use NCs heavily. Our results suggest that NC enforcement contributed to the decline in U.S. business dynamism.

Grants (All as Principal Investigator):

Research Initiation Grant ($60,000) – (2023)
CPA Ontario Centre Grant ($20,000) – (2024)
Monieson Research Grant ($14,526) – (2024)
SSHRC Insight Development Grant ($45,550) – (2024)
Monieson Research Grant ($12,035) – (2025)
SSHRC Explore Grant ($5000) – (2025)
Undergraduate Student Summer Research Fellowship Grant ($8000) – (2025)
CPA Ontario Centre Grant Phase 2 ($20,000) – (2026)
Undergraduate Student Summer Research Fellowship Grant ($10,832) – (2026)
Monieson Research Grant ($14,000) – (2026)

Presentations (Excluding Co-Author Presentations):

2027 (planned): University of British Columbia: Stone Inequality Seminar Series, Ohio State, University of Alberta, University of Calgary

2026: American Economic Association, Canadian Labour Economics Forum Webinar, Innovation, Science, and Economic Development Canada Seminar Series Webinar

2025: Canadian Economics Association, Administrative Sciences Association of Canada, Queens University Economics Department Brown Bag, Queen's University EDII Research Cluster

2024: Society of Labor Economists, Canadian Economics Association, European Association of Labor Economists, Southern Economics Association, Queens University Economics Department Brown Bag

2023: Queen's University Smith School of Business, University of Alaska at Anchorage ISER

2022: Interdisciplinary Graduate Student Seminar Series at Columbia University, Discrimination and Disparities Workshop at University of East Anglia, Annual Economics Graduate Student Conference of Washington University in St. Louis

Research Experience:
Research Assistant for Sandra Black at Columbia University (2019 - 2021)
Research Assistant for John Donohue at Stanford Law School (2015 – 2017)
Research Assistant for Stefano Dellavigna at University of California, Berkeley (2013 – 2015)

Teaching Experience:
Principles of Economics at Queen's University – Assistant Professor (2023 - 2025)
Economics of New York City at Columbia University – TA (2019)
- "Thank-a-Teaching-Assistant" Award from the Center for Teaching and Learning

Economics of Race in the United States at Columbia University – TA (2018)

Service:
Smith Business Economics Seminar Series Lead Organizer (2024 – 2026)
Graduate Committee for Business at Smith School of Business, Queen's University (2024--2025)
- Recipient of Frequent Flyer Award for Event Attendance (2025)

Libraries Committee at Smith School of Business, Queen's University (2023--2024)
Arts and Sciences Graduate Council at Columbia University (2019 – 2021)
Recipient of Honorary Owl Award for Leadership and Service at Columbia University (2021)

Referee:
AEJ: Applied, AEJ: Economic Policy, ILR

PhD Dissertation Committee Service:
- Qidi Hu (Queen's University, Economics Department, 2025)

Undergraduate/Masters Students Advised and Admitted in PhD programs:
- Fall 2025: Wenqi Xie (Northwestern Kellogg Accounting)
- Fall 2024: Michael Duarte (UC Berkeley Economics), Bailey Kraus (Columbia Economics)
- Fall 2023: Xiangru Li (Columbia Economics)
- Fall 2020: Baturalp Yalcin (UC Berkeley IEOR)

Skills:
Languages: Proficient in Spanish
Computer and Technical: Advanced proficiency in R. Proficient in LaTeX, SQL, Stata.

Policy:
Provided expert feedback on non-competition policy to Canada's Strategic Policy and Legislative Reform Division (Jan 2026)

Media Coverage:
1. Why Board Gender Quotas Are Nothing to Fear, Smith Business Insights 2023
2. Should Non-Compete Agreements Be Non-Starters, Smith Business Insights 2023
3. Did You Sign a Noncompete Clause? Here's What to Know, The Toronto Star 2024
4. The Post-Chevron Era Begins with a Gut Punch to the FTC's Non-Compete Ban, Americans for Tax Reform 2024
5. Center for Entrepreneurship, Innovation, and Social Impact Podcast 2024
6. CBC Bizdigest Feds Unveil Supports for Labour Podcast 2025
7. Why the Old Boys' Network Still Rules the Boardroom, Smith Business Insights 2026

Other Writings
- Sentiment and Sustainability: How the Language of US Corporate Filings Reveals Divergent Paths for Management Priorities on DEI and Environment, ISF White Paper (with Tanja Gonzalez and Paul Calluzzo, 2025)

Professional Affiliations
- EDII Research Cluster at Queen's University
- Research Affiliate at Centre for Law in the Contemporary Workplace at Queen's University

Hobbies
- Walking, running, basketball, board games, spending time with family

Personal:
Born on August 3, 1993
US Citizen
Canadian Permanent Resident

Last Updated Nov 9, 2026